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Utah's Democrats Rally Behind a Conservative Independent

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A Connecticut Abortion Fund Prepa

BY **SARAH JACOBS**

IN 2016, Jessica Puk had a second trimester abortion for a wanted pregnancy that was not viable. She described it as "one of the worst days of my life."

"It was a terrible loss," Puk said, "But I was very, very lucky. I had access to the health care I needed." Puk's doctor performed her abortion at their local hospital, and it was covered by her insurance with only a $75 copay. "Logistically, it was pretty seamless," Puk said.

After her abortion, Puk joined a support group for people who had ended a wanted pregnancy. "Learning about all these people from around the country who needed abortions and did not have the level of access that I had — seeing all the barriers that they had to go through — was really eye opening for me." The cost of an abortion is one such barrier that prevents many from receiving the healthcare they need. In the United States, an abortion costs between $500 and $2,000 on average, not including the cost of travel, lodging, and other expenses. Those with access to an abortion clinic may not even be able to afford it. This is where abortion funds come in; there are hundreds of nonprofit funds accross the country who are raising funds to support people seeking an abortion.

A few years after her experience in the support group, and following the appointment of Justice Amy Coney Barrett to the Supreme Court, Puk started to look for abortion funds in Connecticut that she could financially support. But Connecticut did not have one. Undeterred, Puk reached out to the National Network of Abortion Funds to see what it would take to start one.

"I learned that they are all autonomous organizations," Puk said, "and so if I wanted to start an abortion fund in Connecticut, I'd have to start my own nonprofit."

Over the next few months, the National Network of Abortion Funds put Puk in contact with three other individuals, and together they founded The REACH Fund of Connecticut (Reproductive Equity, Access & Choice) in July of 2021. Puk and her co-founders spent a year talking to abortion funds around the country, reaching out to abortion providers, filing to become a 501(c)(3) organization, and more. REACH launched their fundraising campaign on June 19, 2022 — a week before the Supreme Court announced their decision in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* overturning *Roe v. Wade*. Since then, they've raised over $47,000 of their $50,000 goal, all of which will be given to abortion clinics in Connecticut so that they can fund procedures for anyone unable to pay.

"A lot of folks believe that in Connecticut, because abortion is legal, it's legally protected, that we're safe. But legality does not equal access," Puk said. "While there is a lot of wealth in Connecticut, there's also a lot of poverty." In Connecticut, 38% of households cannot afford an unexpected expense like abortion care, and the state ranks third out of the fifty states in highest

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ares for a Post-Roe Nation

income inequality. This issue is further pronounced for those on government insurance plans. Liz Gustafson, co-founder of REACH and state director of Pro-Choice Connecticut, explained that any federal employee on a federal insurance plan is not covered for abortions because of the Hyde Amendment — an amendment that barred the use of federal Medicaid funds for covering abortions. "There's this coverage gap," Gustafson said, which includes those on private health insurance plans that don't cover abortions, students in Connecticut who are on out-of-state insurance plans, and those who cannot afford a plan on the insurance exchange but make too much to qualify for state Medicaid.

Others seeking abortions might be insured but unable to use their insurance without risking external consequence. Puk explained that this includes "Minors [who] may not want to use their parent's insurance because they don't want to tell their parents," as well as "people who may be in a domestic violence situation who can't use their own insurance for safety purposes."

REACH is not only able to help provide care to those in Connecticut unable to rely on insurance to fund their abortion, but will also support anyone coming to Connecticut from other states to get an abortion — a category that has only been increasing since *Dobbs v. Jackson* Women's Health Organization overturned *Roe v. Wade*.

Gustafson's work with Pro-Choice Connecticut has led to the passage of The Reproductive Freedom Defense Act, which has served as a blueprint for similar laws in other states. This act legally protects abortion providers, patients, and others who help patients procure abortions from the "civil enforcement bounty hunter style lawsuits," as Gustafson describes them, that may come from states like Texas which recently passed a law, S.B. 8, allowing such lawsuits. In short, anyone traveling to Connecticut for an abortion is safe, and Connecticut providers can keep serving them.

States nearby, like Massachusetts, also serve as a safe haven for people traveling to receive abortions. Massachusetts has had abortion funds in place for over thirty years, and currently has four main funds in operation.

Margaret Batten, board member of the Eastern Massachusetts Fund and the Jane Fund of Central Massachusetts, explained that historically, Massachusets abortion funds have supported people from nearby states including New Hampshire and Rhode Island. "Increasingly, however, we're seeing people from much further afield. We've seen quite a dramatic uptick in the number of people calling us from Texas — that started in September when S.B. 8 went into effect. But it has continued to increase bit by bit as each month goes by." Batten's funds have now also been helping people from states like Indiana, Ohio, North Carolina and Kentucky.

"Simply banning abortion doesn't eliminate the need," Batten

said. "As long as there are New England states, and states out west like California that are prepared to be points of abortion access, abortion health care will be available. It just raises the cost and the stakes for people."

As abortion restrictions increase in red states across the country, demand for abortions in liberal enclaves is rising. According to Batten, the increased demand for abortions in New York and Pennsylvania has already forced appointment wait times to upwards of a month, compelling many patients to travel to Massachusetts — placing increased pressure on their already strained abortion clinics. By making abortions more financially accessible in Connecticut to those traveling from out of state, REACH will disperse the pressure currently on Massachusets abortion clinics.

In response to the heightened demand for abortion services, abortion funds have continued to work together to collect money for people who need abortions. Batten described the collaboration between multiple Massachussets abortion funds. "Over the years, we have worked collaboratively when there's been a request for a larger amount of money to cover a procedure," she said. "The funds will come together and pool resources, and grant what are called solidarity requests to help meet the needs of that person."

These partnerships and support extends beyond just the borders of one state. Puk told *The Politic* that when starting REACH, she and her co-founders spoke with many other abortion funds across the country. "That's the thing I love about the abortion fund community — everyone is so willing to help each other. Because we all want the same thing, right? We all want more accessible abortion."

Outside of New England, abortion funds and abortion clinics face unique challenges such as the question of legality and the lack of nearby clinics. "I think that there's a lot of fear in the movement, or maybe just a lot of a larger sense of uncertainty," explained Tannis Fuller, codirector of Virginia's Blue Ridge Abortion Fund. "Patients are scared and confused. We've been providing a lot more assurances to folks who are calling us; 'Yes, abortion is legal in Virginia. No, you are not breaking any laws by trying to access an abortion in Virginia.'"

In many of Virginia's neighboring states, this uncertainty predated the *Dobbs* ruling. "Folks in Mississippi — which only had one abortion clinic — have effectively been navigating a post-*Roe* world for decades," Fuller said, "Because even with *Roe*, people couldn't get their abortions because they couldn't afford them or because there wasn't a clinic. And so this work just looks a little different. But it's fundamentally the same."

In 2020, Melissa Cameron of Columbia, MO, was one of those women who were able to effectively navigating a post-*Roe* world, a challenge she faced with the assistance of two abortion funds. Lacking insurance and unsure of where to turn, she called the HOPE abortion clinic in Illinois. The clinic reached out to the Missouri Abortion Fund and the Midwest Access Coalition, and together, the two funds financed Cameron's procedure and gas money. Cameron never interacted with the funds directly — the HOPE clinic handled the transaction and handed her the money she needed upon her arrival at the clinic. Nevertheless, someone from the Midwest Access Coalition reached out to Cameron to offer emotional support prior to her appointment.

"It actually felt like I was talking to family," Cameron reflected. The individual with the Midwest Access Coalition warned her that there would be protestors outside of the clinic wearing neon vests, a warning that Cameron described as invaluable in her emotional preparation for the procedure. "I shared some of my worries about the whole procedure with them, and it felt like I was talking to a friend. It was awesome. Honestly, I didn't even expect it."

After her abortion, Cameron went on to work for a local political campaign, organized several rallies for the "Bans off our Bodies" movement and recently, she had a child when the time was right for her. "People love to tell me like, oh, you're a good mom, but it wouldn't have been possible without my abortion — it really allowed me the time to…become who I needed to be to be a good mom. So without my abortion, I just don't think I would be where I am today."

Although abortion funds around the country strive to support everyone who needs assistance, their impact is limited by the amount of money they raise. Some abortion funds have grants or large donors sponsoring them, but the majority of money raised is collected through grassroots fundraising; members of the funds work tirelessly reaching out to people they know, seeking donations from small businesses, organizations, and anyone who can support the cause. The National Network of Abortion Funds also organizes a large fundraiser every spring — the National Abortion Access Fund-a-Thon, which brings in capital to be distributed among the regional funds.

Some abortion funds like REACH can only afford to finance the abortion procedures, though Puk explained that in the future REACH hopes to be able to provide support for the logistics of receiving an abortion as well, such as transportation, lodging, childcare, and other costs. Other funds, like the Blue Ridge Abortion Fund, are already providing this logistical support. Beyond emotional and financial support, Blue Ridge also buys bus tickets for patients, rents hotel rooms directly on patients' behalfs, or sends them money for things like gas. However, these costs add up. Fuller says that often their grants of money to abortion clinics are used up after one day of callers.

Abortion has been been plastered across national headlines for the past few months since the reversal of *Roe v. Wade*, and as a result, many abortion funds have received a surge in donations. But Jessica Puk has some reservations going forward.

"I try to stress this to everyone: this isn't a moment. It's a movement," Puk said. "I am afraid that, especially in a state like Connecticut, where people think we're safe, that they're going to stop caring, stop prioritizing abortion access. We cannot think we're safe. We cannot breathe. Because the fact is, even in a state like Connecticut, we are closer to the edge than many people think we are."

like nothing in tennis

The Revolutionary Legacy of Serena Williams

BY **PHOENIX BOGGS**

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AT THE 2022 US OPEN, a crowd of spectators holds its breath. In the massive stadium in the Billie Jean King Tennis Center, the stands are packed. Thousands of eyes are fixed on the two figures competing below. Cameras catch their every move, broadcasting a live feed to a record-breaking five million viewers.

On the court, a tennis giant spends her final moments as a competitive player. It is September 2, 2022, and this may be the last time the world sees Serena Williams swing a racket.

Williams announced her departure from professional tennis on August 9, and the announcement caused shock waves on and off the court. Williams had been a powerhouse in the sport for so long that many couldn't imagine what tennis would look like without her.

For many, Williams is an image of Black success in a sport long dominated by white players. But while she was one of the most impactful, Williams was certainly not the first Black player to achieve success in tennis. Arthur Ashe, Althea Gibson, Zina Garrison, and many others had broken that barrier. These legendary players racked up Grand Slam titles and Olympic golds long before the Williams sisters entered the scene.

“It goes beyond Serena,” said Khat Tuchscherer ‘23, a player on Yale’s Club Tennis team. “There was a player that I really looked up to when I was younger named Arthur Ashe, who was sort of the first majorly successful Black tennis player.”

Serena Williams and her sister Venus built on the progress that these foundational Black tennis players made. But the second they entered onto the scene, it was clear that the Williams sisters were different.

“There had been prominent black players,” said Caitlin Thompson, a collegiate tennis player who co-founded and publishes popular tennis magazine Racquet. “But really, somebody who was perceived as a threat to the establishment wasn’t on the scene until Venus and Serena started playing in the late 90s and got into some professional tournaments.”

The sisters stood apart from other players, Black or white, from the beginning, something that can be largely attributed to their father. Richard Williams took tennis lessons as a young boy. One day, he saw a Virginia Ruzici match on television. Then and there, he decided that his future daughters would be tennis stars. His mind was set, and he never gave up on this goal.

According to him, Richard crafted an 85-page plan and never deviated from it. He served as his daughters’ first coach, starting their training at the age of four. But unlike other up-and-coming tennis stars of the day, the Williams daughters operated outside the system.

“The important thing to remem-

eally show it in stark relief: sogynistic the press has re the voices I hear speaking e game has changed so t's almost a joke."

ber is that they did not go through the US Junior development program," said Thompson. "They did not really play with or around any of the other promising young kids coming up at that time. Their father correctly knew that that wasn't the way to build a champion."

Instead, Richard kept the two sisters out of the establishment, building up their skills until they were ready to enter professional tennis. Along the way, he strengthened them for what they would find when they did. "He prepared them for an establishment that wasn't going to be friendly to them. And by them, I mean Black people — loud, proud, Black people. I think he knew from growing up in the sharecropper South that their presence in tennis was going to be a seismic change, especially if his daughters were as good as he said they were — and they were," said Thompson.

Initially, Serena Williams wasn't the one in the spotlight. She began her professional tennis career in the shadow of her older sister Venus. Venus was the one with the tournament invitations, coaching offers, and winning record. Venus was the rising star.

Serena Williams, on the other hand, was an underdog. She had to fight hard to get recognition. She credits her eventual rise to success not to inborn talent but to drive and determination. She would travel to Venus's tournaments and hope that a spot would open up for her to play.

She was committed and dedicated, even as she faced a constant uphill battle. According to Thompson, "she's always had this hunger for the limelight in a way that has meant her tennis has been aggressive and bold. She feels entitled to win — like all the really exceptional champions do. And she's been unapologetic about that."

Eventually, that dedication paid off. Williams made her professional debut at the age of 14, and four years later, she became the youngest Black woman in history to win a Grand Slam singles title. Today, she's a 23-time Grand Slam champion, just one shy of the world record. She is widely considered one of the greatest tennis players of all time.

One remarkable feature of Williams's game is her longevity. Before her, it was certainly not typical for a tennis player to start their career as one of the world's best teenage players and remain a world best into their forties. *The Guardian* remarked that Williams "started her professional career beating women who were twice her age and will finish it beating girls who are half as young."

Shriver emphasized that this endurance is part of what makes Williams so legendary. "That longevity, that excellence from your teenage years to your late thirties, is one of the things that sets her apart."

Around the world, Williams's name is inseparable from the sport of

"[Richard Williams] prepared them for an establishment that wasn't going to be friendly to them. And by them, I mean Black people — loud, proud, Black people."

tennis. But her reputation and image have grown far beyond the sport. Today, she has become a cultural icon with investment ventures, merchandise, and book deals. What has caused Serena Williams to transform from an (albeit legendary) athlete into an icon?

Pamela Shriver, a Hall of Fame tennis player who is widely regarded as one of the greatest doubles players in history, thinks that what sets Williams apart is a combination of innate talent and simple grit. "Obviously, she had the talent. She had the belief, she had the mindset. She had the work ethic," said Shriver. "And she put it all together to become a 23-time major singles champion."

Chanda Rubin, a former top-ten professional women's player who once beat Williams in a Los Angeles tournament, agreed that Williams's sheer force of will is what made the difference: "When it gets tough, she kind of digs in and has that ability to fight and battle and not shy away from these big moments, these tough moments. And so I think that's a real strength. And I think that is really one of the challenging parts about playing her."

Williams certainly had the grit that it took to face off against skilled players. But for her, the biggest obstacles weren't her opponents. Richard Williams had warned his daughters that, despite their talents, they might not always be welcomed with open arms into the tennis establishment. He was right.

"Their style, bombastic arrival, and the way they played tennis was not exactly seen as familiar," said Thompson. "At worst, it was an active threat. And so they were really not received well when they came on the scene."

The sisters were victim to the same discrimination that characterized the careers of Black players who had come before them. While things had changed since the time of Arthur Ashe, who had been prohibited from playing on the white-only courts of his hometown, racism still followed the Williams sisters. The most egregious examples come from the tennis media establishment. In 2001, for example, sports radio commentator Sid Rosenberg said that the sisters were more likely to appear in National Geographic than in Playboy (he was later fired for these remarks). After Serena Williams's notorious loss to Naomi Osaka in the 2018 Australian Open, an Australian newspaper famously ran a cartoon depicting Williams as an angry child stomping on her racket. Many believed that this strip, which exaggerated the size of Williams's lips, nose, and hair, harkened back to the anti-Black imagery of 1950s cartoons.

From her position as a publisher for a major tennis magazine, Thompson has a unique perspective. She believes that this racism to which Williams has been a victim is partly due to the fact that

the tennis media establishment is not held to a high enough standard. "The press has not been as good or as diverse or as modern as the athletes in tennis for quite a while. And I think that definitely predates Venus and Serena, but Venus and Serena helped really show it in stark relief: how old, male, white, and misogynistic the press has been. And even now, those are the voices I hear speaking about tennis, even though the game has changed so radically from their time that it's almost a joke."

Not all of the racism and classism the sisters faced was obvious on the surface. Some of it also manifested in more superficial aspects of the sport, like clothing choice or the distribution of sponsorship money. Of course, tennis has always had a reputation for being a sport of the wealthy — a reputation based in historical and modern truth. In fact, tennis' white uniform was originally designed to prevent the less affluent from taking up the sport, because in the 1800s, white was the most expensive fabric to keep clean. This elitist tennis atmosphere has never fully disappeared. And when the Williams sisters first entered into professional tennis in the 1990s, the establishment was even less welcoming.

Serena and Venus Williams were born and raised in Compton, CA. Their father Richard worked the night shift as a security guard. Originally, the sisters were unable to find coaching because they could not afford to pay for it. And above all, the Williams sisters had not been brought up to follow the norms of elite tennis society: they introduced new fashions to the court, proudly sporting jeans skirts, hoops, and hair beads. Perhaps it was predictable, then, that commentators, sponsors, and event organizers would refuse to shine a spotlight on the sisters. Instead, they focused on players with whom they were familiar — players who had come up the usual way, who reflected the tennis tradition.

Tuchscherer grew up in New York City, the home of the US Open. She remembers attending the tournament as a child and watching the Williams sisters' games. Even then, she could tell that something about the sisters distinguished them from the other players and from the tennis establishment. "There was something so different about Serena and Venus because they came from such humble beginnings," Tuchscherer said.

Williams faced obstacles on the basis of her race and class throughout her professional career, even when she had secured enough titles and trophies to silence all doubt of her skill. Despite her huge following and growing influence, sponsors still shied away from working with her.

Chanda Rubin said that seeing Williams denied recognition sent a message to her and other players of color. "[For Williams] to still be one of the underpaid players in terms of sponsorships compared to players who had far less on their resume? That was kind of a slap in the face," said Rubin. "Because if Williams is not getting what she deserves, well, what does that mean for the rest of us?"

It wasn't only sponsors that were treating Williams unfairly. Throughout her career, she has also faced notoriously unfair treatment from umpires and line judges. Perhaps the most egregious example was when Williams played Jennifer Capriati in the 2004 US Open. Three of Williams's shots were called out even though they were well inside the line. These famous "three bad calls," according to Rubin, were so severe that they actually served as a major catalyst for the modern electronic review system. Even the game's commentators can be heard over replay reacting with shock: "That ball was out? No way. That was not even close. That was way in. That's one of the worst calls I've seen."

Famously, Williams did not take the unfair treatment lying down. After the first incorrect call in the Capriati game, Williams walked over to the umpire's chair and showed her frustration. "It was not out! I'm trying to tell you, it was not out! Do I need to speak another language?"

Williams's willingness to be loud and fight back against bad calls was also unfamiliar to the tennis establishment. Many criticized Williams for demonstrating "unprofessional" behavior toward line judges and umpires. But Rubin doesn't blame Williams for

her reaction. She feels that criticisms of Williams's behavior lack perspective. "Nobody can understand what that is like. When you're supposed to be in a place that is safe. That is fair. And yet it is not, and you are on your own, and there is no one to help you. And you are powerless. And so sometimes there's not a lot of grace given to her, and I think there should be," Rubin said.

An essential part of Williams's legacy is the battles she has won and the paths she has forged as a Black woman in tennis. Indeed, part of what made Williams so angry was the fact that she could see that white tennis players, especially white male tennis players, were not exposed to the same biased calls and constraints. "How much of it was being a woman?" wondered Shriver. "How much of it was being Black? How much of it was because she's both? I think bringing up all that stuff is important. And she was brave to bring it up."

Despite these hurdles, Williams continued to rack up Grand Slam titles and make waves in a sport that had previously been dominated by establishment favorites.

She also continued to draw new fans, which many players feel is one of Williams's greatest contributions. Over the course of her career as a player, broadcaster, and pundit, Shriver has seen Williams's effect on audiences of color. "While certainly we've had black champions in tennis, we've had nothing in tennis like Williams. So the fact that she was able to dominate a sport that for the most part had been dominated by white people, I think was even more impactful. [She let] people of color know that you can make an impact in professions and industries and in cultures that previously haven't been that inclusive."

Serena represented a break from the traditional norms of tennis. This was a break that, in many cases, inspired young players to see themselves in the sport. When Tuchscherer would attend the US Open every year, she found herself drawn to the sisters' games. Seeing someone on the court who looked like her was a breath of fresh air. "As a young black athlete, seeing Venus and Serena playing, specifically in a sport like tennis, which is super dominated by wealth, was super refreshing," said Tuchscherer.

But now that Williams is no longer playing professional games, many are looking around to see who will take up her mantle. What is the future of tennis without the G.O.A.T?

Some worry about the sport's ability to hold onto the fresh perspective that Williams brought to tennis. There is concern that now that Williams is gone, the attention that she generated within tennis will just disappear.

Shriver is one of those who worries for the future. "I don't know whether tennis has been prepared for how to keep the audience that Serena brought in," she said, "or how to engage them and keep them as fans of tennis long after Serena has retired."

Thompson, meanwhile, has a more optimistic view. She believes that Williams has succeeded in effecting major change in the tennis establishment — change that will remain long after she's gone. She pointed out young tennis players such as Coco Gauff and Naomi Osaka who have been making change in their own right. She also notes the comparative freedom that these young players have experienced since Williams blazed a trail.

"[Osaka's] willingness to push back against some of the established norms… I think she would never have been able to do that if Williams hadn't made the point," said Thompson. "People know how to test those boundaries because Williams set new ones."

From her place on the Yale Club Tennis team, Tuchscherer sees new young players following in Williams's footsteps. That will be Williams's greatest legacy, Tuchscherer believes: the fresh generation of players she inspired to enter tennis and break barriers themselves. Tuchscherer specifically pointed out the example of players who are children of immigrants. She believes that many of these players' parents entered them into the sport largely due to Williams's example.

"If you have a player like Serena who is showing representation, it can push immigrant parents who don't really know much about tennis to introduce their kids to the sport," said Tuchscherer. "And then those kids excel at tennis. Like, for example, there's Frances Tiafoe, who is one of the top players in the world now."

As for Williams, she doesn't like to call her departure from tennis a retirement. Rather, she'd like it to be considered an evolution. She's not losing steam, she says, but rather switching tracks — moving from the world of tennis into a focus on business, investment, and motherhood. Serena Ventures, the investment group that she founded in 2014, has raised more than $111 million to help companies like Masterclass, Daily Harvest, and Noom achieve major commercial success. Williams wants to focus her efforts on this passion. And she doesn't want to lose a minute with her five-year-old daughter, Olympia.

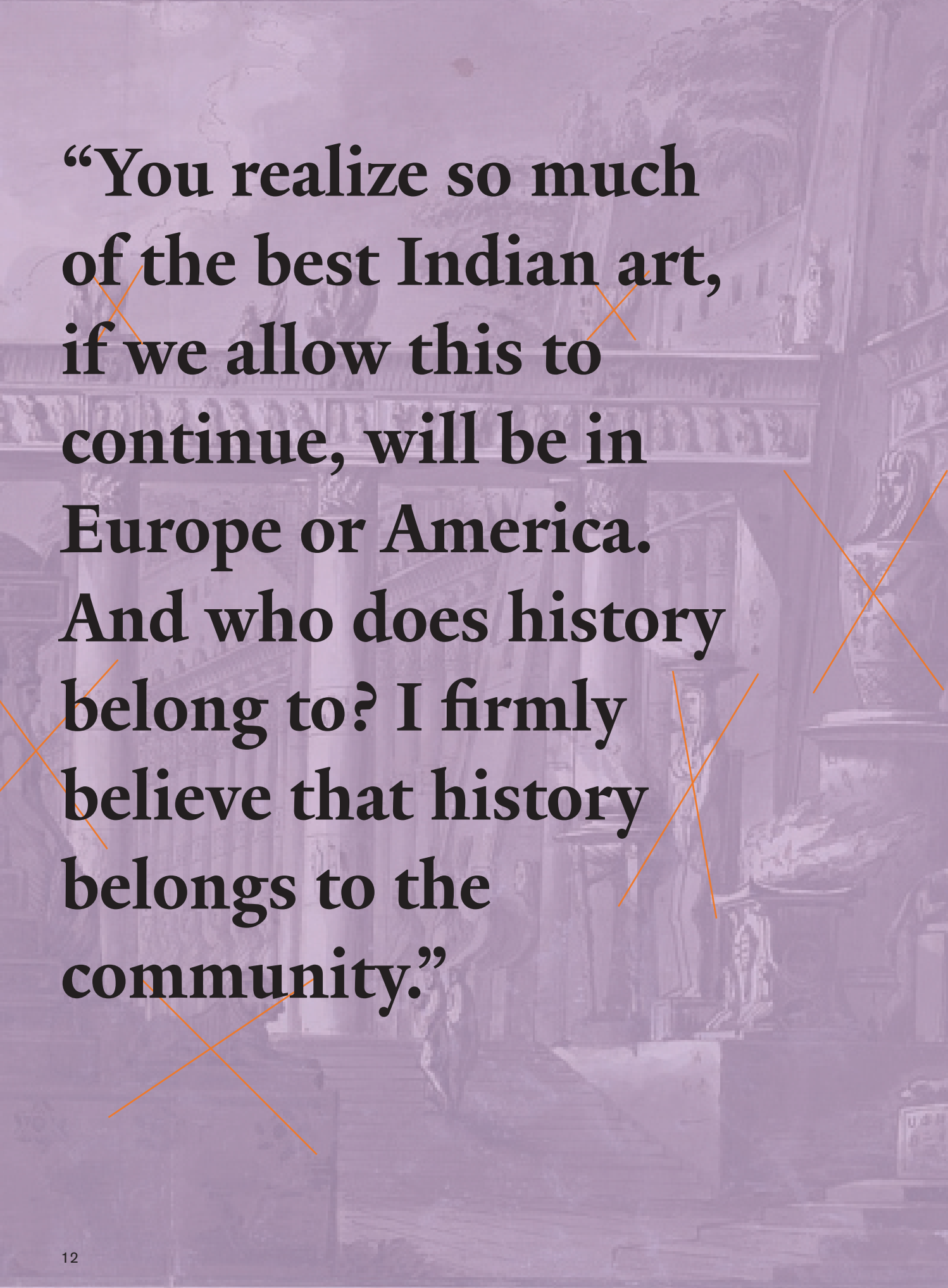
As Williams moves into this new stage of her life, Chanda Rubin said that she'll be sad to see her go. But she also sees the joy that can come from Williams's "evolution."

"I'm just happy for her, that she feels that she's moving into a new phase on her own terms. I mean, that's what every player wants. It's kind of a dream."

THE EMPTY TEMPLES

Western Museums Reckon with Stolen Artifacts

BY **TIFFANY PHAM**



“You realize so much of the best Indian art, if we allow this to continue, will be in Europe or America. And who does history belong to? I firmly believe that history belongs to the community.”

IN 2015, the Yale University Art Gallery (YUAG) received a generous donation to the museum's collection: an argillite stone sculpture of the Buddhist Goddess Tara.

Though the sculpture was a stunning addition to the university's collection, Antonia Bartoli, the YUAG Curator of Provenance Research, had questions.

Bartoli oversees provenance for incoming art acquisitions and existing collection pieces in the YUAG. Provenance is not simply understanding when and where an object was created; it is also about tracing the ownership of that object across time and location so that when an institution such as the YUAG acquires such an object, it does so in a legal and ethical way.

Bartoli was alerted to a potential issue with the donated Buddhist Goddess Tara sculpture when Nepalese artifacts in other collections were investigated. She launched an internal inquiry at the YUAG into the object.

"Very quickly through my own research, I was able to show beyond a reasonable doubt that it had originated from a temple in the Kathmandu Valley and disappeared some time between the 1970s-1990s," Bartoli explained.

"[The sculptures] were taken or lost at a time when Nepalese tourism opened up to the West and, sort of with the hippie trail, as more Westerners came to Nepal, they developed a taste for these objects. The fairly ubiquitous stone sculptures that you found across the Kathmandu Valley started disappearing," Bartoli said.

The YUAG was soon contacted by the Consul General of Nepal in New York. Both parties came to an agreement that the object had been unlawfully smuggled out of Nepal. Up until at least 1976, the object had resided in the Bir Bhadreshwor Mahadev Temple in the Kathmandu Valley of Nepal, where it was worshiped in daily ritual. The YUAG transferred the object to the Government of Nepal for repatriation in May of 2022.

The Buddhist Goddess Tara is one of a number of objects that have been displayed at the YUAG with illegitimate origins. In April 2022, the Department of Homeland Security seized 13 antiquities valued at $1.29 million from the YUAG that had been looted from South Asia. The objects are connected to Subhash Kapoor, one of the world's most notorious antiquities smugglers. Kapoor has been incarcerated in India since 2011 for his crimes, and he faces conviction in the United States for running a multinational ring that traded objects valued at more than $145 million.

Beyond the YUAG, in 2022 alone, the art world has undergone a reckoning as authorities have seized stolen antiquities from some of the world's most prestigious art museums. At the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, 27 Roman, Greek, and Egyptian objects were seized between February and October of 2022. Cambodian officials have accused museums of housing looted Cambodian and Khmer objects, including over 100 in the British Museum and 50 in the Victoria & Albert Museum.

MUSEUMS HAVE BEEN collecting art and objects for centuries, but efforts to investigate and validate their origins have scarcely begun. After centuries of neglect, provenance research became its own subfield of museum work in the early 2000s when a concentrated effort emerged to examine art transactions during the Nazi regime.

At a museum like the YUAG, which was founded in 1832 and has a current collection of over 300,000 objects, the history that this research needs to cover is vast. "If you consider the age of this institution, provenance research is very much in its infancy here," Bartoli said.

"Provenance research is lengthy, time consuming work," she said. Because access to information about objects becomes more available over time, "provenance research is rarely finite. It's ongoing."

Victoria Reed is the Senior Curator for Provenance at the Museum of Fine Arts (MFA) in Boston and oversees all of the museum's curatorial departments' research documentation. Her role, like Antonia Bartoli's at the YUAG, is important but rare among art museums.

"There have been a few additional roles that have been created, but I think funding remains a challenge," said Reed.

Unlike the YUAG and MFA, smaller museums have significantly less funding and resources dedicated to provenance and do not necessarily have the capacity to take steps towards internal investigations or restitution efforts. Since provenance research is new territory, there is not a universal expectation of provenance research for institutions, leaving museums to determine their own roles in navigating investigations.

Furthermore, because there are so many ways in which objects end up in museums illicitly, there have been glaring gaps in provenance research for particular artifacts. Reed points out that European paintings are more likely to have reliable paper trails that have been put into inventories or mentioned in wills.

Objects that have been taken from colonized communities do not enjoy the same privileges.

"Works of art from African countries, for example, came to the United States without certain details reliably recorded," Reed said. "We don't have the same level of documentation because we may not have an artist's name, or maybe people in the United States or in Europe didn't understand what the object was."

For many years, these problems of historic neglect, understaffing, and lack of resources have (and in some cases will) hampered museums' progress. However, as records have been digitized and become more readily available in recent years, other actors have taken more active approaches to redressing problems of stolen objects.

Some of those actors are governments, such as the seizures mentioned above. However, much work is also done by private organizations of volunteers like Vijay Kumar. For Kumar, museums' efforts and progress are presently too little and too late. He is a co-founder of the India Pride Project, a network of multinational art lovers

who return stolen antiquities to India. The group uses social media and its volunteer network to build archival databases of objects that they believe are stolen. Then they work with law enforcement and institutions to repatriate art. The India Pride Project has had great success, contributing to the repatriation of 157 artifacts during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the United States in 2021.

Kumar emphasizes that stolen art is not a victimless crime. He wants to draw attention to the physical violence that occurs in areas where objects are looted.

"You had murders, killings, lynchings to security guards, who were protecting the sacred sites. We've had whistleblowers gone missing," Kumar said.

By collecting objects that have entered the art market in this way, faraway art museums create demand. Kumar notes that museums make up only 5% of the antiquities trade, but pay high prices for the art they collect.

"By not doing the right thing, whether voluntarily or involuntarily, you are aiding and abetting and becoming complicit in the illicit trafficking racket," Kumar said.

Beyond the physical damage, stolen objects are often imbued with religious or cultural significance. Some were not intended to be pieces of art at all, and their removal – such as from burial sites and tombs in India, Cambodia, and Nepal – causes great damage.

In Cambodia, for example, Kumar said, "everything is linked to [the object's] worship… once the gods have left, grains have failed or plagues have come in. By destroying the very object of faith, by cutting away whom they worshiped and [whom] their ancestors have worshiped for generations together, you shake the pillar of faith."

When objects turn up in museums, the displays often compound cultural violence by insensitivity and ignorance. Today, one-third of the Amaravati Stupa, the sacred Buddhist monument built at Amaravathi village in the third century, is housed in the British Museum.

Kumar paints a dismal image of the museum display: "The collection is totally devoid of context, parts that are on the floor should have been on the roof. You basically destroyed a third of the site. How do you justify such a pillage?"

Sara Petrilli Jones, a PhD candidate at the Yale Department of the History of Art, said, "I think one can pose the question provocatively of whether these the museums that claim to be the ultimate only caretakers of these objects truly are."

In 2016, four years before Antonia Bartoli came to Yale, Kumar visited the YUAG. He remembered identifying likely problems with the art on display. "I had looked at the collection, and I noticed that most of them did not have clear provenance," she said. Kumar sees his work as essential for protecting and restoring the history, culture, and identity of plundered communities.

"This is not some random theft, this is targeted looting on an industrial scale where robbers and smugglers pick and choose the best of Indian art that will sell in Europe or America," Kumar said. "You realize so much of the best of Indian art, if we allow this to continue, will be in Europe or America. And who does history belong to? I firmly believe that history belongs to the community."

With organizations like Kumar's investigating works around the world, as well as some governments and museum employees, many more objects with violent histories will come to light. Yet determining what to do with a stolen object is not always an easy process itself.

"Do you go to the nation, the country of origin, do you go to the community? Do you go to the temple? Do you go to law enforcement?" Bartoli asked.

Generally, if provenance research reveals that art has been obtained through illicit means and a museum decides to act, they can either take steps towards restitution or repatriation. Repatriation involves the museum's collaboration with official government entities to return an object to a nation or community of origin. Restitution works slightly differently.

"More broadly, [restitution] can take a number of forms and when it comes to lost, stolen, or misappropriated art, restitution can mean an acknowledgement. It can mean a long term loan, it can mean an exchange of objects, it can mean financial compensation, it can mean exchanges of information, or expertise," said Bartoli.

Reed also said the MFA may choose to make a financial settlement, rather than physically returning the art. "The gesture is sort of tantamount to repurchasing the object from its rightful owner. And then a museum could keep the object in the collection," Reed said.

These decisions about restitution and repatriation are challenging, and Kumar suggests that the identities of the looted communities often affect the outcome of the process.

"If the Met were to be caught with a Holocaust painting for example, they will drop it like a hot cake and handle the case with gloves. Whereas for us, when it's stolen from a temple site or from a conflict zone like Kashmir, nobody seems to be bothered about it. Both of them are stolen; both of them have resulted in genocide," Kumar said. "I think people have to realize that you have no right to parade these objects bought illicitly."

Though efforts in collections around the world vary in magnitude and effectiveness, Kumar, Bartoli, and Reed believe that provenance research is becoming an increasingly powerful force.

"[Provenance research] has the ability to reveal very meaningful, profound social narratives, tracing threads, lines of inquiry from past to present, the life of an object… At the end of the day, it can connect us globally through time and space and remind us of our shared humanity," Bartoli said.

Curators also point out the potential for collaboration amongst experts as a pathway for restitution and academic scholarship. Pertilli-Jones points to James Green's conference at Yale in 2018, which brought together curators from various institutions

“Nobody seems to be bothered about it. Both of them are stolen; both of them have resulted in genocide.”

from different countries. “This was a four, five day event where people could share expertise, and speak and begin to form relationships with one another,” she explained. “This is something that Yale in particular, but university museums in general, which have a lot of resources, could do to think about restitution as being part of a broader program of exchange and collaboration across geographies and cultures.”

On a larger scale, museums have a responsibility to collect responsibly to ensure that they do not harm the communities from which they collect art from, or to mislead the general public. “If we look at the role of museum professionals, we’re stewards of cultural heritage, and this is something that entails significant public trust,” Bartoli said.

Kumar agrees. By collecting objects that have illicitly entered the art market, faraway art museums create demand and perpetuate a malicious industry. He noted that museums make up only 5% of the antiquities trade, but pay high prices for the art they collect. This demand perpetuates the looting and causes harm when cultural heritage is removed from its people.

“By not doing the right thing, whether voluntarily or involuntarily, you are aiding and abetting and becoming complicit in the illicit trafficking bracket,” Kumar said.

Beyond provenance itself, collections have a responsibility to display ethically their legitimately-obtained objects.

Raymond Clemens is the Curator for Early Books and Manuscripts at the Beinecke Rare Book & Manuscript Library at Yale University. “Throughout most of Western Christianity, the Bible wasn’t a particular value in terms of a religious relic or icon. It was important in terms of what it said, but the object itself wasn’t as important. That’s different with different cultures, in Judaism, the Torah does have to be treated respectfully. And the same is true with the Koran. When we display these works, or use them in a museum or a library, we do need to treat them with the cultural importance that they had for the people that originally created them,” he said.

At the Benicke, the Torah and the Koran are elevated on higher platforms amongst other objects to designate respect for the books.

As restitution efforts continue to ramp up across art museums, there have been mixed opinions about how far museums should go. “I think a lot of people are afraid of this process of repatriation of materials, they’re afraid that they won’t be there for people to study, to use, or to consult. And I think what people need to know is that when these objects are returned, they don’t go into a vacuum,” Clemens said.

Case in point: look no further than to Vijay Kumar. “In the last two years, we have restituted almost four idols in my home state of Tamil Nadu,” Kumar said. “They’re called living gods; they call it Romanian Tamil.” The pieces were returned to India from Australia earlier this year, after they were illegally smuggled by William Wolf in 1965.

“To see them becoming the gods that they once were, from being showpieces,” said Kumar. “That’s our pay day.”

Utah's Democrats Rally Behind a Conservative Independent

BY **THEO SOTOODEHNIA**

McADAMS FOR McMULLIN

BEN McADAMS, a former Democratic congressman from Utah, is not running for Senate this year. Nor is he campaigning for another member of his party. In fact, he won't be voting for a Democrat at all.

Instead, McAdams has spent the past year campaigning on behalf of Evan McMullin, a conservative independent. After McMullin entered the race in late 2021, McAdams began the arduous task of convincing committed Democrats that the best thing they could do for the Democratic Party would be to vote for the former Republican.

"Over the course of five months, I was hosting, at my home, groups of twenty to thirty people," McAdams said. These get-togethers, which were composed of Utah Democratic party activists, were part of a campaign by McAdams and Salt Lake County Mayor Jenny Wilson, two of the Utah Democratic Party's most notable figures, to convince the party not to nominate a candidate for the United States Senate.

"Out of these twenty or thirty people…we'd probably have one person who left still in disagreement," McAdams noted.

McAdams, a Utah-bred, Columbia-educated lawyer, is polite yet firm, with a mild manner that initially obscures his practical determination and keen political mind. After serving in the Utah State Senate, McAdams won an open race for Mayor of Salt Lake County in an upset.

"When I ran for mayor, I was expected to lose," McAdams said. "In fact, there was polling the weekend before my race that showed me losing by ten percentage points."

Six years later, in 2018, McAdams narrowly pulled off an upset and won a seat in Congress, defeating a well-funded Republican incumbent in a heavily Republican district. In 2020, McAdams lost his reelection campaign by just over seven hundred votes.

As the 2022 Senate election against incumbent Republican Senator Mike Lee approached, McAdams knew he seemed like a natural choice for the Democratic nomination.

"I looked at the numbers and knew that if I had run for United States Senate, and it was a three way race with Evan McMullin, Evan and I would have been splitting the same voters . . . a three way race would guarantee Mike Lee's reelection."

Instead, in November of 2021 McAdams endorsed McMullin's candidacy and embarked on a campaign to keep the Democratic Party out of the race. McAdams's core pitch, that standing aside in favor of McMullin is Democrats' only chance at defeating Mike Lee, is a gamble with implications that extend beyond Utah.

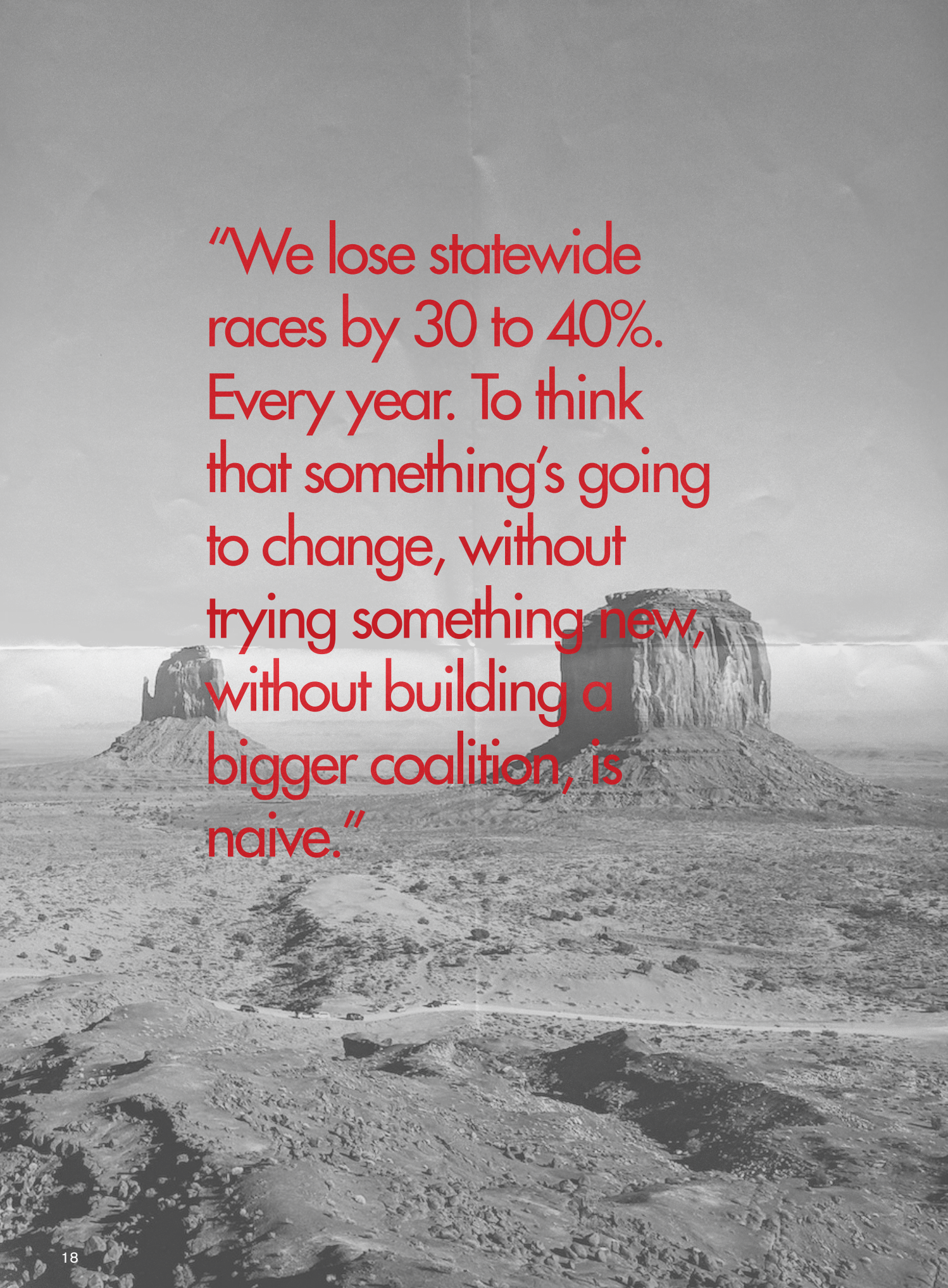
Born in Provo, UT, in the mid-1970s, McMullin was raised in the Church of Latter-Day Saints (known colloquially as the Mormon Church or LDS), and, like many LDS youth, went on a mission abroad before attending Brigham Young University. McMullin later served in the CIA for eleven years.

"When America was attacked on 9/11," McMullin recalled in his campaign launch video, "I volunteered to serve undercover in some of the most dangerous places on earth."

After his tenure in the CIA, McMullin went on to serve as a senior advisor on the House Committee on Foreign Affairs in 2013. In 2015, he became Chief Policy Director for the House Republican Caucus where he worked closely with Republican leadership.

Greg Orman, a Kansas businessman who won over forty percent of the vote running for Senate as an independent in 2014, stressed the value of McMullin's partisan background. "[McMullin] has the benefit of having been a Republican his whole life, served in the CIA, and ultimately served in the Republican party politics for quite some time," said Orman.

After three years on the Hill, McMullin bucked the Republican mainstream in 2016 and loudly opposed Donald Trump's presidential candidacy. Increasingly dissatisfied with the major party nominees, McMullin announced a run for president as an anti-Trump conservative four months before the 2016 election.


"We lose statewide races by 30 to 40%. Every year. To think that something's going to change, without trying something new, without building a bigger coalition, is naive."

Though he only scored a few hundred thousand votes nationwide, McMullin's candidacy was supported by many Republican officeholders, including his future opponent, Senator Mike Lee, who voted for McMullin and attacked future President Trump. In the general election, McMullin won over 20 percent of the vote in Utah, vastly outperforming his numbers in other states. As a result, the 2016 election marked the first time a Republican presidential nominee did not win a majority of the vote in Utah since 1992.

McMullin's overperformance in Utah signaled developments to come. When McMullin announced his candidacy for Senate, few expected the race to be competitive given Utah's strong support for Republican candidates at the federal level. However, in the years since the 2016 election, Utah politics have diverged from national trends.

On the state level, many Utah Republicans have resisted the bitter partisanship of the Trump and post-Trump years. GOP Strategist Mike Murphy, who is running a super PAC supporting McMullin's campaign, attributed this unease to the influence of the LDS church.

Utah, he said, has "a strong LDS cultural element, which has always sort of disapproved of Trump."

McAdams echoed Murphy's point. "You have seen members of the LDS church who have been uncomfortable with Donald Trump and what he represents… [which is] a marked distinction from Republicans around the country," he said.

Utah's tepid reception of Trump is exemplified by one of its most prominent officeholders: Republican Governor Spencer Cox. First elected in 2020, Cox has made a pointed effort to distance himself from the Trump wing of the Republican Party and promote civil dialogue. During the 2020 gubernatorial election, Cox and his Democratic opponent ran a joint advertisement in which they pledged to set an example for the nation by disagreeing respectfully. *The Economist*'s Lexington column has highlighted Cox's conciliatory approach, noting that since winning the governorship, Cox has forged compromises across the aisle in a state so heavily Republican that compromise is rarely a necessity. In 2021, he worked towards consensus on Covid regulations and vetoed a bill restricting transgender students' participation in sports.

Similarly, at the local level, McAdams also found success rallying bipartisan support for an ordinance banning discrimination on the basis of sexual orientation in Salt Lake City.

"Utahns are pragmatic problem solvers. We are Republicans, Democrats, and independents, but at the end of the day, we care about finding solutions," McAdams said. "We believe that we can sit down at a table and talk with each other. Working on LGBT employment and non-discrimination is a prime example where Utah broke out of the box, and we refuse to accept the dichotomy of us versus them."

While Utah voters have demonstrated an appetite for a more conciliatory kind of politics, between the summer of 2016 and the January 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol, many national "never-Trump" Republicans either embraced Trump's leadership or faded off the political stage entirely. Several previously Trump-skeptic Senators, including Mike Lee, became vocal Trump supporters. Lee went so far as to compare Trump to Captain Moroni, a revered figure in the LDS Church. McAdams hones in on the moment Lee compared Trump to Moroni as a turning point in the way Utahns viewed Senator Lee.

"There are some people who have been willing to plug their nose and support Donald Trump, but to compare him to a revered religious figure went way too far," McAdams explained. "For a lot of people's minds, that crystallized how Mike Lee has changed."

While Mike Lee has transformed himself from Trump critic to staunch supporter, McMullin has remained consistent in his opposition to the former president.

McMullin's steady anti-Trump activism has earned him credibility among Utah Democrats. During the small-group meetings he hosted at his home in Salt Lake City, McAdams often invited McMullin to engage directly with the Democratic operatives. Though Democratic activists did not agree with McMullin on every political issue, they recognized they had few other options.

"Liberal Democrat activists are not 100% happy with him, either," Murphy, the veteran GOP operative, said. "They just think he's better than Mike Lee."

At the Utah Democratic Party convention, McAdams's motion not to nominate a candidate for Senate won 57% to 43%. Many of the detractors acknowledged that the chances of a Democratic victory were vanishingly small, but worried that not running a candidate unfairly denied their supporters an option. Others worried that voters would think the Democratic Party was giving up on tough elections in conservative regions.

McAdams counters that Democratic voters, for the first time in decades, have the opportunity to be part of a winning electoral coalition.

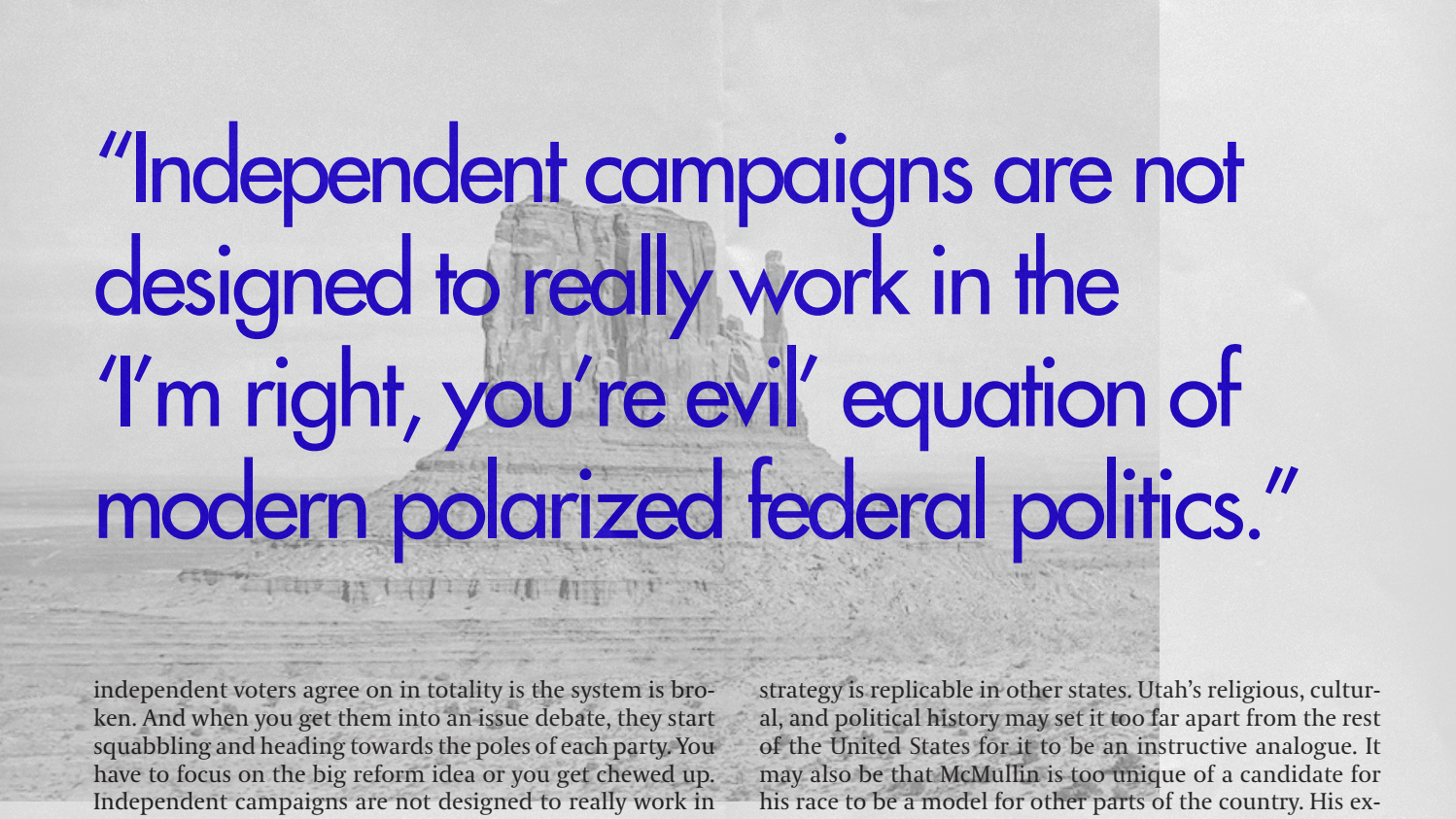
"The definition of insanity is doing the same thing over and over and expecting different results," McAdams argued. "We lose statewide races by 30 to 40%. Every year. To think that something's going to change, without trying something new, without building a bigger coalition, is naive."

Without a Democratic opponent, McMullin has the field cleared to his left. In a state as heavily Republican as Utah, McMullin must attract Democrats, independents, and a significant portion of Republicans to win. Though Utah has unique political dynamics, McMullin's campaign takes advantage of a broader national disillusionment with the two-party system of government.

"The large plurality of Americans have self-identified as being politically independent for the past decade," said Orman, the Kansas independent. "At the same time, over 60% of Americans have said that they wish we had a viable third party, including majorities of both Democrats and Republicans. . . . People like Evan McMullin are trying to give voters another choice."

McMullin has to walk a fine line. Just declaring oneself a political independent is not enough to tap into Americans' sense of partisan alienation. In fact, voters who claim to want an independent voice are not necessarily of the political center; they are more often united by a disenchantment with the political system as a whole.

Murphy noted, "One thing all



"Independent campaigns are not designed to really work in the 'I'm right, you're evil' equation of modern polarized federal politics."

independent voters agree on in totality is the system is broken. And when you get them into an issue debate, they start squabbling and heading towards the poles of each party. You have to focus on the big reform idea or you get chewed up. Independent campaigns are not designed to really work in the 'I'm right, you're evil' equation of modern polarized federal politics."

Beyond ideological challenges, McMullin faces significant logistical challenges as an independent running for office. Independents lack the partisan fundraising systems, data, and networks of operatives available to major-party candidates.

"I think it's been an added level of difficulty to not have some of the institutional advantages that come from being aligned with a party," McAdams said. "Everything from a party-organized, coordinated campaign and get out the vote to . . . building a campaign organization without the support of a party. And I think that's added an element of difficulty."

Despite these challenges, McAdams thinks that McMullin has "been able to build that apparatus."

Once unthinkable, a McMullin victory now looks plausible. One of incumbent Mike Lee's first signs of weakness came in the form of a surprisingly strong primary challenge from former State Representative Becky Edwards, who ran on a platform promoting "productive, inclusive, [and] proactive" politics—a message reminiscent of the McMullin campaign. Lee won the primary, but with only 60% of the vote.

Recent polling shows a single-digit race, with one poll putting Evan McMullin narrowly in the lead. Many polls have McMullin within the margin of error, and a high proportion of respondents are undecided. Because it is a competitive race, the McMullin-Lee matchup has brought political life to areas that have been neglected under a system where one party is so assured of their support that other candidates do not bother to engage.

"We had people from rural Utah, who have never—not even at the local level, or state legislative level or city council level—seen a race where their voice ever mattered, being so enthusiastic for this race," McAdams said. "It's a single-digit race. I have not seen that in my lifetime."

Despite the race's competitiveness in a reliably red state, it is unclear how much of McAdams and his partners' strategy is replicable in other states. Utah's religious, cultural, and political history may set it too far apart from the rest of the United States for it to be an instructive analogue. It may also be that McMullin is too unique of a candidate for his race to be a model for other parts of the country. His experience running for president in 2016, his resume, and his style are all hard to imitate.

Yet McAdams believes that, despite the McMullin-Lee race's unique characteristics, in certain circumstances his strategy could be relevant elsewhere.

"I think it could be a model for the country, especially in places where extremist politicians win reelection on autopilot," McAdams explained.

Though McAdams and his partners were instrumental in ensuring Democrats backed McMullin's campaign, their part in the race is largely over. "I have a less pronounced role today than I did six months ago," McAdams said. "I still stay in touch with the campaign and support where I can, understanding that the work of building a coalition is necessarily much more broad today."

McAdams has accepted a backseat role for himself and his party in the campaign and supported a candidate who does not share all of his ideals because he believes that marginal progress through victory is better than ideological purity in defeat.

"Try telling a DREAMer that it's better to lose than to have a solution for them….Or to say it's better to lose than to have somebody who can work constructively to implement solutions to the climate crisis," said McAdams. "All of those things, it's not better to lose, it is catastrophic to lose."

McAdams continued, "Saying that it's better to lose than to compromise our purity is a pretty elitist position taken by people who have the luxury of standing their ground when it means the lack of progress on issues that are important."

McAdams's gamble strikes at the existential challenge faced by all opposition parties: compromise their principles in order to win power, or maintain purity in the knowledge that they may not enter government. Whether McMullin wins or loses, McAdams's strategy is a trial run for minority parties across the country facing this choice.

The Fight Over LGBTQ+ Inclusion at Christian Universities

BY **GREY BATTLE**

IN 2008, BRIT BLALOCK graduated from Samford University, a Christian university in Alabama. At the time, it was unsafe to be an openly gay student on campus. "I was on a scholarship and while no one had told me this explicitly, my assumption was they could take that away if they deemed a reason good enough to do so," she said. "I made the conscious choice to stay closeted through all four years so that I could get my degree and then immediately came out right afterwards because it had been miserable."

Blalock was not alone. When graduation arrived, waves of former students began to come out and quickly, an underground network started to form. Blalock set up a Facebook group to connect those coming out after finishing their time at Samford. Within 48 hours, the group gained hundreds of members.

Blalock's original Facebook group grew into a community that still exists today called SAFE Samford: Students, Alumni, and Faculty for Equality. While the university has never had an official LGBTQ+ student group on campus, SAFE aims to fill the gap by connecting LGBTQ+ students and creating a space for them. As of 2022, the SAFE Facebook group has over 900 members.

In 2022, SAFE found itself fighting Samford's decision to expel two LGBTQ+-affirming churches from its campus ministry fair, an expo event that showcases different churches. Blalock described the decision as a hard-right, fundamentalist turn reminiscent of the culture SAFE hoped the school had left behind.

"We decided to limit Samford's formal ministry partnerships to

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churches and to organizations that support Samford's traditional view of human sexuality and marriage," said Beck Taylor, Samford's current president, in an official video to students.

This decision had its roots in the 2019 hiring of a new campus pastor, Bobby Gatlin. Due to campus closures during the COVID-19 pandemic, the 2022 ministry fair was the first that Gatlin oversaw. Gatlin's hiring received pushback from the Samford community because of his commitment to fundamentalism, a sharp shift from the past ministers. A substantial number of Samford faculty quit their jobs to protest his hiring.

"He is openly homophobic and doesn't believe women should be pastors, which is wild for Samford where tons of women are educated at the seminary itself," Blalock said of Gatlin.

Samford defines itself as a Christian university, founded by Baptists. However, prior to the expulsion of these ministries, both the Presbyterian and Episcopal churches had a strong presence on campus and participated in ministry fairs. A large portion of current students, faculty, and staff regularly worship at and are deeply connected to many of the uninvited churches. Since the decision, there has been an outpouring of dissent from students, faculty, and alumni. Hundreds have lined up to protest, created response videos, and signed onto open letters. Alumni have called to disinherit Samford from their wills and cancel monthly donations. Samford has not reversed the policy.

The Presbyterian and Episcopal churches are examples of Christian denominations that have become more accepting of LGBTQ+ people. In 2018, the General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church voted to affirm its commitment to the full acceptance of all sexual orientations and gender identities. In 2015, the Episcopal Church codified its support for same-sex marriage and committed to oppose all legislation that reduces access to public restrooms, locker rooms, and showers for transgender and gender non-conforming people. Despite these decisions, Presbyterians and Episcopalians were still welcome at Samford until 2022.

Baptist leaders at Samford have been working behind the scenes for years to cement the university's status as a key foothold for fundamentalist beliefs. Through strategic hires and quiet shifts, conservative administrators have entrenched both their power and their anti-LGBTQ+ beliefs into the university. "I wish that I could say something like, 'Oh, I think this sort of just accidentally happened,' but that is not the case at all. It's definitely happened through a thoughtful evolution and decision making. That's come from very high up," said Blalock.

As part of this evolution, the objectives of Samford's presidents have changed. Blalock described how a former president, Thomas Corts, was an academic who ran the university in a style that encouraged freedom of inquiry and debate. In contrast, the last president, Andrew Westmoreland, ran the university like a "mega church," and the current president, Beck Taylor, has followed a similar path. When Samford hired Gatlin, the university changed the name of his position from campus "minister," a post often held by academically-minded people with doctorate degrees, to "pastor." Gatlin's 2019 hiring as pastor may have been the turning point for such a sharp shift in policy, but the foundation had been laid for many years.

Blalock finds the university's backslide "shocking" because it is in such stark contrast to the school's setting in the suburbs of Birmingham, Alabama. The city of Birmingham recently received a perfect score on the Human Rights Campaign assessment of LGBTQ+ inclusion in policy and

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law, a recognition that came after the city passed an LGBTQ+-inclusive non-discrimination ordinance and hired its first LGBTQ+ liason, among other iniatives.

At the same time, the presence of southern evangelicalism, a conservative Protestant Christian movement that includes the Baptist denomination, has rapidly declined around Birmingham. Even young people who still identify as religious have become more progressive on social issues, according to Blalock. At Samford, in particular, the percentage of students who identify as Baptists dropped from 59% in 2000 to 30% in 2020. Young people have grown up largely under the expansion of LGBTQ rights, gay-straight alliances, and *Obergefell v. Hodges*, the Supreme Court decision that ruled same-sex marriage to be protected by the Constitution. In particular, there is a large difference between Generation Z's understanding of sexuality and that of older generations.

Evangelical leaders acknowledge that this trend has created challenges for their mission. "Our culture is changing a lot," said Dana Hall McCain, who serves on the executive committee of the Southern Baptist Convention (SBC), the top decision-making body for the Baptist church. "If they are to remain, orthodox [traditional] Christians will have to be more forthright."

Since being elected to the executive committee in June, McCain has become a key stakeholder in decisions about relations between member churches and the SBC, missions, disaster relief, and responses to allegations and mismanagement of sexual abuse claims. She lamented that rapid cultural change has caused an awakening of evangelical Christians towards an impending societal shift in favor of pro-LGBTQ+ politics and away from orthodoxy.

"Our position has been that Scripture is very plain on this issue, and that Scripture is inerrant. And is sufficient. And so we have made no adjustments, and I would be very surprised to see us ever making any adjustments to sort of accommodate the cultural change in that area," McCain said.

McCain expressed the difficulty the church faces in preserving Southern Baptist strongholds in an increasingly progressive world.

"It's really hard because it's an unpopular message… to point people back towards some objective standard of truth and say that these answers are knowable," she said. "You may not like the answer, but here's the thing: the answer is for your good. The answer is given to you by God who loves you."

Southern Baptists like McCain see anti-LGBTQ+ policies as part of this "answer."

"We're seeing a resurgence of targeted anti-gay and anti-trans legislation because Christian supremacists are trying to lay claim to ownership over the composition of the nation," said Chelsea Ebin, an Assistant Professor at Centre College who researches the development of right-wing movements. "Christian supremacists want to define their ownership over the United States to lay claim to it as a Christian nation, to assert the righteousness of how they understand social and sexual relationships."

Targeting higher education has been part of the Christian right's playbook since the 1970s. Religious activists have focused on educational institutions because they are responsible for "structuring and informing," argued Ebin.

The conflict at Samford parallels cases of anti-LGBTQ+ discrimination playing out on the campuses of Christian universities across the country. Other instances include bans on same-sex relationships and official LGBTQ+ student groups at Andrews University, the denial of housing and

to define their ownership over n to it as a Christian nation, to ow they understand social and tionships."

health care to LBGTQ+ students at Baylor University, the expulsion of students who come out at Bob Jones University, and the refusal to hire individuals in same-sex relationships at Seattle Pacific University. Educational institutions have become ground zero for a resurgence in old-school homophobia, a strategic power play for the Christian right.

Southern Baptist leaders are open about their strategy. "The higher education moment in the life of young adults is crucial for spiritual formation, for ethical formation," explained McCain.

To Blalock, this strategy has a different connotation. She referred to the efforts of Baptists to shape education as "fascist-like policies to keep the other ideas out."

Beyond evangelicals' actions in schools, the movement has also turned to the polls to impose its values within the political sphere. White evangelicals make up the largest voting bloc in the United States, according to Sophie Bjork-James, a cultural anthropologist and assistant professor at Vanderbilt University who has studied the National Religious Right for years. Due to evangelicals' high turnout rate, the community represents about a quarter of the voters in any given election, despite accounting for only 14 percent of the American population.

Katherine Stewart, an investigative journalist who writes about the religious right, also emphasized the disproportionate significance of the religious right in the American electorate. "In a country where roughly half of the people don't vote, and others have their votes essentially taken from them because of voter suppression and gerrymandering, you don't need a majority to win elections," she said. "All you need is an organized and committed minority."

This vocal minority is determined to radically shift the American political field. "They aim to create a new type of order, one in which they, along with members of certain approved religions and their political allies, will enjoy positions of exceptional privilege in politics, law, and society," Stewart said.

It all begins with schools. As the conservative campaign to strengthen traditional values continues, students at targeted schools will continue to live in the closet, face discrimination, and risk expulsion or the denial of housing, healthcare, and employment opportunities.

However, LGBTQ+ advocacy groups like SAFE do not plan to stop fighting anytime soon. When Samford produced and circulated a recruitment video with a homophobic scene, SAFE coordinated a response and Samford took the video down. In 2012, SAFE applied to have a station at the annual homecoming event. They were approved and now have had a presence for roughly ten years.

SAFE faced other losses outside of Samford's recent decision about the ministry fair. In 2017, for example, an LGBTQ+ student group called Samford Together was almost unanimously approved by the faculty, but ultimately rejected by the president. LGBTQ+ advocacy groups expect both wins and losses and understand that loud, active voices are key to push schools like Samford towards inclusivity.

"We're not demanding that these leaders at Samford change their own personal opinions about the issue of homosexuality," said Blalock. "We just want them to create an environment that's equal for all people."

As the conservative campaign to strengthen traditional values continues, students at targeted schools will continue to live in the closet, face discrimination, and risk expulsion or the denial of housing, healthcare, and employment opportunities.

The Stories of Homeless Women in Merritt Island, Florida

DAY TO DAY

BY **PHOENIX BOGGS**

All names in the piece have been changed to protect the individuals interviewed.

TAMMY, 71, sits on the curb with her hands clasped on top of her knees, her long tangled hair wrapping around her shoulder and down her chest. She's been growing it out, she says. It's a statement.

Tammy lost her home three months ago. She's been living on the streets ever since.

Today, she's sitting outside of House of Hope, a non-profit organization housed at the First Baptist Church of Merritt Island, Florida. House of Hope provides resources to meet the basic needs of homeless people in the community, and most of the services it offers are outdoors, with food, clothing, and medical stations under tents. It's a Florida morning in July, and the temperature is over 90 degrees. Tammy sips lukewarm water from a gallon jug one of the volunteers gives her, sweat stains covering her jeans and t-shirt.

Tammy chats and laughs with some of the chaplains from the church. She's been getting along pretty okay, she says. Doing better than most.

As of January 2020, almost 600,000 people in the United States were experiencing homelessness. Unable to find food, shelter, and other basic necessities, these individuals are forced to spend their days on the streets or in shelters. Tammy and her boyfriend of 50 years were forced to move onto the streets three months ago, and they have been confronting these challenges together. But as a woman experiencing homelessness, Tammy faces a unique set of problems.

One pressing example is that homeless women experience a much higher risk of sexual and physical violence. "Being stalked by predators is a big problem," Tammy says. "Day-to-day, you need a safe place to lay your head so you don't wake up dead."

This problem is not unique to Merritt Island. One 2005 study of homeless women in the United States found that half reported experiencing physical violence, and that 92% of homeless mothers had experienced physical or sexual assault.

> "Day-to-day, you need a safe place to lay your head so you don't wake up dead."

This risk is exacerbated by the disproportionate number of homeless women who are forced to resort to prostitution in order to survive. Many of the women Tammy has met, she says, are either full-time prostitutes or frequent victims of sexual extortion.

"A lot of the younger girls… go off in the bushes with [men] for a meal, or for drugs," Tammy says.

The connection between homelessness and prostitution proliferates throughout the country. One 2004 study found that 45% of Miami women in prostitution were homeless. In Chicago, 84% of prostitutes reported current or past homelessness. The two issues are tightly interconnected: prostitution is often a measure of last resort for desperate women without resources, and among homeless women desperation is acute because resources are scarce. But while prostitution may provide these women with a means of survival, it also puts them at even greater risk of physical and sexual violence.

Tammy doesn't pass judgment on the prostitutes she meets. She knows many of them have no other options.

"They do not know what they're getting into. And they're nice people, the prostitutes I've met. Right, Pops?" she turns to her boyfriend, who nods as she continues. "Very considerate, respectful of me as an elder."

Beyond the constant threat of violence, Tammy has observed another systemic issue that uniquely affects homeless women: a lack of contraceptive knowledge and availability. This lack of access and information has serious consequences — in the United States, 75% of pregnancies among homeless women are unintended. Frequently, these women simply lack the resources to care for a child or fear the social consequences of raising one.

"Some keep their child. But, because of the circumstances of the birth, they're shunned. So [many women] turn [their baby] over to the state," she says.

Recent events have only made it more difficult for homeless women to access comprehensive and reliable reproductive care. In June, the Supreme Court's 6-3 decision in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* overturned *Roe v. Wade* and declared that the right to abortion was not enshrined in the Constitution. Florida was one of many states to quickly enact new anti-abortion legislation. The state's new law forbids abortions after 15 weeks — and offers no exceptions for rape.

"I'm upset about the reversal of [*Roe v. Wade*]," Tammy says. "I don't like it. I'm a religious woman, but when it comes to that, if we're going to flood the market with unwanted children, there aren't enough people to take these kids in."

She knows far too many homeless women that have been forced to give up children they were not ready to care for. These women are not just Tammy's neighbors, but also her de-facto family. When she lost her home, other homeless people, especially those young sex workers, took Tammy under their wing. They invited her to their camps and showed her how to find the safest places to sleep at night. Perhaps most importantly, these women have provided her with a sense of community and camaraderie on the streets.

"Homeless people, in general, have been much, much better than the average citizen to me. They don't pass judgment," Tammy says. "Because not everybody is a junkie. There are things that happen in people's lives that just make everything fall apart."

SUSAN, 47, KNOWS THIS all too well. She sits across the yard from Tammy amid a group of people clustered under a tree. Many homeless people gather here in the shade to escape the sweltering heat as they wait to eat or use the showers attached to the church.

Susan was a cashier at a local gas station for years. But she says that eight years ago, she was sexually assaulted while on the job. Afterwards, her trauma and chronic pain made it difficult for her to find work.

"Nobody understands how it feels inside, inside my body… The breathing is hard," she says. "Every time I go to apply for a job, they don't want me because I'm a liability."

Eventually, Susan resorted to

“Homeless people, in general, have been much, much better than the average citizen to me. They don’t pass judgment. Because not everybody is a junkie. There are things that happen in people’s lives that just make everything fall apart.”

living in the woods. But living alone as a homeless woman has exposed her to even more danger. She has experienced firsthand the violence and abuse to which Tammy testified.

“When you walk down the street, you see men who think they can take advantage of you,” Susan says. She’s taken precautions to protect herself. She avoids spending too much time in one place or getting too close to men.

“I move around so I can sleep,” Susan says. “Because my life’s priority is to be self-sufficient as a woman. I don’t want to depend on a man [for protection].”

Beyond basic safety concerns, it’s also been difficult for Susan to fulfill her sanitary needs while out on the streets. She says that on the streets, accessing basic sanitary products — particularly pads and tampons, but often even shampoo and soap — is a challenge.

“That’s why I go to the church and I ask for what I need,” she says. “Sometimes people give me a couple dollars in the street and I get what I need with that.”

This problem isn’t unique to Susan. According to the National Organization for Women, the average woman spends $20 a month on feminine hygiene products, adding up to about $18,000 over her lifetime. This can make it impossible for many homeless women to find enough money to pay for the menstrual products they need. One survey of low-income women in St. Louis, MO, found that nearly two-thirds could not afford to purchase menstrual hygiene products. This need is so widespread that it has been given its own name: “period poverty.”

Even when Susan does have access to sanitary products, she often has no place to use them. The church’s showers are open only once a week. Without access to a shower, she has few options for keeping clean.

“I don’t care what people think, I’m going downtown to wash up in them sprinklers with the kids. I just go in there and get myself cleaned up,” Susan says.

She feels that she has to resort to such measures because the police and local government haven’t done enough to help her or other homeless women.

“[The police and government] should actually be trying to help me,” she says. “And I try to go to them for help, and they don’t even want to see it…. They feel like, ‘well, it’s okay, you’re out here, you’re going to have to fight.’”

Susan is correct that the governmental response to homelessness is often disorganized. While homelessness is undoubtedly a national issue, the federal government has largely placed the burden for addressing it onto the shoulders of local authorities. The Department of Housing and Urban Development provides grants to local governments to address homelessness, but HUD avoids dictating how this money should be used. The total autonomy afforded to local governments in crafting these policies has made the response to homelessness fragmented and inconsistent, meaning that the experiences of Susan and Tammy could be unique from those of women in the town over.

Local governments’ approaches to the homelessness crisis are not just uncoordinated, but also underfunded. In a 2021 survey, a majority of mayors across the United States agreed that their ability to combat homelessness was hampered by inadequate funding. The lack of sufficient resources apportioned to local governments has made private actors — like charities, churches, and corporations — crucially important in providing shelter, food, and services to unhoused individuals. In Merritt Island, much of the work to relieve the burden of homelessness (and almost all direct homeless service) is

“When you walk down the street, you see men who think they can take advantage of you.”

left up to independent organizations such as this church.

THIS INADEQUATE RESPONSE to homelessness has serious consequences for women facing poverty, both on and off the streets. Low-income women with homes, whom this church also serves, often encounter the same dangers and difficulties that are everyday occurrences in the lives of homeless women.

Amanda is a 32-year-old woman who moved to Florida with her fiancé just a few weeks ago. She says that they moved in search of a better life after losing their home in Pennsylvania.

“We were living with people, but we don’t really have any family up there [anymore],” she says. “His mom just died, my uncle died.”

Fortunately, Amanda and her fiancé have a car. It’s how they were able to leave Pennsylvania, and it also provides them their sole source of income.

“We get up and we go DoorDash,” she says. “That’s the only way I can make money right now…. We both want to get jobs and settle down.”

For now, Amanda and her fiancé live in a motel with Amanda’s aunt and uncle. But that living situation can’t last for much longer. They’re relying on a motel voucher given out by a local charity. After this month, they’ll have to vacate, and they don’t know where they’ll go.

Amanda echoes the same worries about safety that homeless women like Tammy and Susan experience.

“With the safety issue, if it weren’t for my fiancé, I would be [in danger],” Amanda says. “Safety is a big thing.”

She also talks about her reliance on birth control to manage her menstrual cycle. She doesn’t have to worry about finding the money to buy pads or tampons, which has been a big relief.

Being new to Florida has made it hard for Amanda to find any sense of community — especially while fighting the stigma of being low-income.

FEMALE HOMELESSNESS IS a nebulous and complicated issue. Substance abuse, lack of access to childcare, period poverty, the dangers of physical and sexual violence, and countless other struggles combine to create an impossible situation for homeless women across the country and the globe. There’s little that any one person can do to fix the issue. But Tammy and Susan both feel that a solution is urgently necessary.

“Something for women needs to be established,” Tammy says. “We’re still looked at as second-class citizens.”

Before the gendered aspects of homelessness can be addressed, Tammy feels that other homeless issues, like simple lack of access to food, should be dealt with first. That’s why Tammy’s advice for those looking to help homeless women is simple.

“Donate,” she says. “Donate food. Medical supplies. Just donate, even money.”

Susan, on the other hand, feels that getting homeless women off of the streets could be done by local community organizations.

“I just don’t see how the community of churches don’t come together and build something [for women],” she says.

One of the church’s chaplains, listening in on the conversation, remarks that Susan is correct. In fact, one of the church’s officials has been building up resources to establish a house for homeless women — a place for them to recuperate, learn skills, apply to jobs, and get back on their feet.

Programs of this kind aren’t new. Housing centered around homeless women, whether in the form of group houses, tiny home communities, or apartment complexes, has been successful in other places. Just a two-hour drive away, in Marion County, FL, Project Hope has been helping homeless women in this way for more than a decade. The nonprofit houses 60 homeless mothers and children in an apartment complex, allowing them to stay for as long as 18 months to get re-established and back on their feet. Project Hope — as well as other similar ventures across the country, from LA to New York — prove that such women-centered housing can be successful. These communities serve as a model for other cities, including Merritt Island, to emulate.

In Merritt Island, a long-term solution like this for homeless women is a long way from reality. Tammy likely won’t be around to reap the benefits of such a program, she says. But it’s work that stands to make a huge difference for the women she sees every day.

“I don’t have much more time left on this Earth,” Tammy remarks, looking up at the sky and closing her eyes. “But I hope something is set up for these women.”

SHARING THE FUTURE

Effective Altruism and the Decision to Have Kids

BY **EMILY TIAN**

JULIA WISE HAD always imagined herself becoming a mother. Nevertheless, through a "particularly intense" stretch in her twenties, she was beset with uncertainty.

"At the time, I was really focused on the money that it would cost to raise a child," she said. "And that would be money that I couldn't donate. And I just thought, like, that's ethically wrong."

Since 2012, Julia and her partner, Jeff Kaufman, have been donating around half of their annual pre-tax income to charity. They keep scrupulous records of their contributions online, down to the dollar. Last year, they donated $400,000; the year before, $264,727. In 2008, as fresh college grads, they were already giving away a third of their income. Roughly a decade ago, the couple took an official pledge with an Oxford-based organization called Giving What We Can to donate at least 30% of their income to effective charities.

Childcare, housing, food, education, healthcare, time off from work, every spent and borrowed dollar between conception and delivery: for many, having a child is the most expensive financial decision of their lives. On paper, Julia and Jeff look like comfortable one percenters. Until this summer, Jeff had been earning most of the family's income as a senior software engineer at Google (he recently took a salary cut to conduct research identifying early warning biological risks). However, since most of the money they're not donating goes into savings, their regular consumption expenses are lean.

Despite her moral ambivalence about the tradeoffs between donations and children, the thought of growing old without them left Julia feeling in-

creasingly hollow.

It was plain to Jeff that Julia would be devastated if she didn't get to raise kids, so he devised a new budgeting plan. Jeff and Julia had been earmarking their donations separately at the time: Jeff's salary was split between donations, household expenses and savings while Julia's take home earnings went 100% to charity. The pair canvassed books on childcare and estimated the cost of raising a child to adulthood, and Jeff told Julia that he was going to set aside that sum from his earnings. "I could use part of my income to ensure that Julia could make the decision without considering whether it would be taking money away from people who need it," he said. The money didn't necessarily have to be used on a child. It could be for themselves — they could go on nice vacations, for example. The only stipulation? She couldn't donate it.

"Once he said that, I was like, yeah, there's nothing else I want to do with the money more than having a child. That made it very clear to me," she said.

Now, Julia is midway through her thirties and the mother of three: Lily, who is eight, Anna, who is in first grade, and Nora, just over one.

Julia possesses the modest warmth of a schoolteacher, and her slightly downsloping eyebrows add to her teacherliness a perpetual look of concern. Her home doesn't resemble an exercise in puritan austerity; it's filled with light, and her daughters' paintings hang crowded and colorful on the walls. When she sat down to talk this spring, a child began cooing in the room over, and Julia left to fetch her. She returned with the giddy, gleeful interloper — Nora, her youngest, charismatic and bright-eyed in her swaddled nine months — as the intimate tableau of their family life played out before a stranger without any reservation at all. That is often the case with parents: it is obvious to them that others will share in their joy. Nora stayed for the rest of the conversation, her fingers occasionally grasping at the air.

JULIA GREW UP in a suburb of Richmond, Virginia, where her extreme empathy from a young age mostly led her parents to worry that she would become destitute later in life. From the time that she was in high school, she saw donations as a tool she and everyone else had access to that could make the world a better and fairer place.

For college, she headed off to Bryn Mawr, a small all-women's liberal arts school near Philadelphia, where she studied social work, saved and donated the little money she earned, and spent her free time folk dancing. Jeff, who studied linguistics and computer science at neighboring Swarthmore, also loved folk dancing. Between that, their shared frugality, and disinterest for college drinking and bacchanal nights out, they found they had a good deal in common.

By the time they got married, Julia was working as a mental health counselor in a jail in south Boston and Jeff had landed a position working in computational linguistics. Both were donating to charities they liked, even with their fresh-out-of-college salaries, but it wasn't until they stumbled upon Giving What We Can and GiveWell, an organization which conducts data-driven research to determine and rate charities' cost-effectiveness, that they began to identify in earnest others who took donations as seriously as they did.

It didn't take long for Julia and

Jeff to start organizing monthly dinners in the Boston area for other people they knew or heard of who also cared about effective giving. Often, there weren't enough chairs in the house to go around. Although Julia loved her job as a social worker, she didn't feel like she had much of an edge in the profession, and she was getting frustrated by the lack of practical change. She began devoting her time instead to community-building within the nascent effective giving movement. This movement would in time be given an official name: effective altruism.

These were the early 2010s, when conversations like the ones Julia and Jeff were having around their dinner table were taking place in lots of other spaces, too, including the centuries-old gothic buildings of Oxford's campus. Effective altruism's intellectual heart lies at Oxford — exactly and expectedly the sort of gray and brooding place that moral philosophers like to flock to. The Centre for Effective Altruism is headquartered there, which in 2011 became the umbrella organization for Giving What We Can and 80,000 Hours, a group focused on helping people lead impactful careers.

In the past decade, those early philosophical hunches have turned into a global social movement. Right now, it has come into a critical new moment of growth and public recognition, having attracted funding and philanthropic backing from numerous organizations and entrepreneurs keen on using their wealth to do good. Sam Bankman-Fried, the thirty-year-old crypto billionaire, has been giving away his fortune to effective altruism (EA), which has also meant that it is capturing increased political capital. This summer and fall, many major news outlets and magazines — among them TIME Magazine, the New Yorker, and the New York Times — have published pieces introducing their audiences to EA, marking a tide shift as the once-niche movement grapples with newfound wealth and outside skepticism. As *Vox* writer Dylan Matthews observed in a recent profile of the movement, "Effective altruism in 2022 is richer, weirder, and wields more political power than effective altruism 10, or even five years ago."

On the Centre for Effective Altruism's website, EA is described as "using evidence and reason to figure out how to benefit others as much as possible, and taking action on that basis." While communities proliferate on university campuses, professional settings, and area groups like the one Julia helped bring together in Boston, the Center itself has been since its genesis an official locus of EA community-building, public education, and funding for nonprofits, projects and conferences. Julia herself became the president of Giving What You Can in 2017 and now works as a community liaison at the Center, helping local EA groups support their members.

At its best, effective altruism models a kind of radical compassion minus pretense and idealism, which, for certain types of do-gooders, can make for a compelling cocktail. Some causes, effective altruists point out, are more neglected than others, and if you are seriously concerned about using your life to do good amid a landscape of profound suffering, then thinking like an effective altruist can help you tip away from biases and poorly reasoned judgments.

While the movement's central precept to live a life of

"Once he said that, I was like, yeah, there's nothing else I want to do with the money more than having a child."

maximal social impact might sound inoffensive, it can also lead to counter-intuitive, even unsavory conclusions. That impulse you have to donate to the most recent hurricane relief efforts? An effective altruist, noting the pots of money pouring in from other donors and the relatively high overhead costs of aid organizations on the ground, may suggest that you put your dollars elsewhere, like providing mosquito nets to reduce the risks of malaria in sub-Saharan Africa or medicine to clear children of parasitic worm infections. Detractors also criticize the movement's recent turn toward an ethical view known as longtermism — which argues for the moral significance of future generations — and the kinds of priority areas which often come attached at its hip, like working on artificial intelligence safety and other existential threats to human civilization.

Most of the time, people feel a greater sense of obligation toward some more than others: parent to children, sister to sister, best friend to best friend. But effective altruists often believe that love and concern ought to be offered to others without distinction, regardless of their affinity or closeness to oneself. Given there is so much suffering — given that there are so many urgent demands for our daily attention — shouldn't we attempt to extend care indifferently (impersonally, even)? Will trying to do so reduce some real, thick dimension of human experience — the part of us that reaches first for ourselves and our loved ones, for the infant girl whose pointer finger is curled midair?

THE SAME QUESTION HOLDS for Julia now as it did fifteen years ago — how can we do the *most* good? — but these days she leans heavily on the knowledge that a diverse number of things can motivate and sustain even the most altruistic among us.

"Especially in my early 20s, I just wanted to squeeze as much out of myself as I possibly could, but I wasn't thinking a lot about how I would develop myself to be able to do more good than I am currently. Like, how will I sustain this over the decades of my work?" she said.

That question is one that others in the movement are grappling with, too. It can be especially hard when someone's personal mandate is to do the most good, a goal that doesn't necessarily come with a natural boundary, which can incline someone towards continuously optimizing one's life for impact and productivity at the expense of their own wellbeing.

Dr. Bernadette Young, an Oxford doctor married to the EA philosopher Toby Ord, remembers, when she was pregnant eight years ago, reading some dismissive remarks made by EAs who suggested that parenting would result in too great of a lapse in productivity. For reasons not unlike those of Julia and Jeff, Bernadette and Toby spent a long time thinking about whether they should become parents. Bernadette said that having a child was something she wanted to do for a long time, but for a while she believed that her commitments to do good in the world cut her off from that possibility.

Ultimately, after agreeing with Toby that having a child was something that they could afford to do out-

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side the bounds of what they pledged to donate, she came around to the view that she could be an effective altruist and a mother, too.

Bernadette's story reveals that, despite all the energy that EA devotes toward stewarding the world for future generations, the movement can seem hostile to prospective parents. But true anti-natalism — the view that one should, on moral grounds, abstain from having children — is a rare position to come by in EA. Those who do hold that view may be motivated by an overriding concern for the environment or for animal welfare, or otherwise because they weigh the relative badness of suffering more heavily than the goodness of flourishing.

"The only way we actually might wrangle nature to have less suffering is if we have many generations of careful thinking and moral expansion," Luke Freeman, who succeeded Julia as the director of Giving What We Can, said. This is a view that Will MacAskill — a philosopher at Oxford and the movement's pop icon, if there were to be one — endorses. MacAskill writes in his recently published book on longtermism, *What We Owe The Future*, that having children can not only be instrumentally good — because future generations can mitigate economic and technological stagnation and contribute new ideas to society — but also good *for them*, so that they can experience the meaningfulness of human life. And if you are really worried about the environmental footprint of having a child, Jeff added, then you can consider adopting other environment-friendly lifestyle practices or put some of your income toward carbon offset costs for an average lifetime's worth of emissions.

Ultimately, none of the eleven effective altruists interviewed took up philosophical anti-natalist critiques very seriously. Julia said the view was mostly "marginal," and others eagerly offered to refute the maximalist interpretation of EA. For one thing, even if becoming a parent means that you can't be a hundred percent effective with your time or money, it would be hard to build a social movement by asking others to deprive themselves of things they deeply value. Ben Smith, a neuroscience postdoc living in Auckland who married late last year, balked at the idea that effective altruists have to entirely set aside their own desires and needs in order to make a significant difference in the world. "I think asking people to make substantial personal sacrifices to achieve a goal probably discourages a lot of people who could otherwise be involved from participating," he said.

A CHILD CRIES — and doesn't everything else seem to vanish? Few things compel such an immediate physical response. To be a parent is to agree to being tugged this way for the rest of your life.

"One of the things about parenthood," Bernadette said, "is that it does create a special and privileged relationship with someone that is different from the generic kind of duties we might owe everyone." She doesn't believe one person is worth more than another, but she also recognizes that she possesses a particular relationship with her daughter that involves different intimacies, different responsibilities, and ultimately a greater kind of protective duty that other people don't replicate in the same way.

When we spoke, Bernadette's daughter was seven and three-quarters — it is important to get this exactly right. While Bernadette explained that she wants her daughter to understand her values and have the chance to take those on, particular tensions can arise when her daughter is doing something that she supports that also carries a certain degree of risk.

Last year, Bernadette's daughter overheard her talking to Toby about a COVID-19 vaccine trial that was going to take place in children. She immediately interjected and said she wanted to sign up, even after Bernadette explained how the vaccine trial would involve things like blood tests and needles. She told her parents that she wanted to help out in the pandemic, and she knew that vaccines would help during the pandemic.

"She very clearly, at least to me, chose to do that voluntarily, at least partly because she thought it was a kind thing to do," Bernadette said.

AT THE TIME when Jeff and Julia were starting to think about having kids, they were among the few would-be parents in the movement. Back then, the EA movement was itself very young — and many of the people drawn to it were also young themselves, right around the time when one is discovering for oneself what a meaningful life looks like.

The movement is growing up. At a GiveWell meeting last spring, Julia describes that one board member was out because his wife was in labor, another said that they were expecting, and then another, and then another — in total, about half of those in attendance. As more and more effective altruists reach child-bearing age, EA spaces have also become communities for new and expecting parents to go to each other for resources and practical advice on milk fat ratios, birthday parties, and iron supplements.

Couples like Julia and Jeff, who are heavily involved with EA and have been for a number of years, often serve as informal mentors to new and expecting parents. Both keep up public blogs with posts about parenting and effective altruism along with transparent records of their donations and contribute frequently to discussion forums and community meet-ups. Julia guesses that this sort of public engagement and outreach has been at least as impactful as the actual donations they've made.

And even though the couple haven't actively tried to teach their daughters about Effective Altruism, Lily, their eight-year-old, already sounds a lot like Julia: she is very empathetic, gets ruffled easily by suffering or the idea of death, and also loves to dance. Just the other night, she refused to eat dinner with the family because meat was being served.

When asked whether parenting had substantially transformed her prior ethical beliefs the way that her altruism influenced her decision to have kids, Julia paused, considering the question.

"I think there were times when I would think, before I had kids, that if there was nuclear war or something, and we would all die, maybe that wouldn't be so bad because at least we wouldn't be there to be sad about it. I could come up with reasons about why things wouldn't be as terrible as they seemed. Once I had kids, it was harder to tell myself some story where it's not all that bad. Once I had kids, it felt like *no*, not that. That kid? Yeah, don't let that happen. Yeah."

BY **KATE REYNOLDS AND LEONIE WISOWATY**

Matthieu Aikins is a journalist and contributing writer for the New York Times Magazine *who has been reporting on the ground from Afghanistan since 2008. In his 2022 book,* The Naked Don't Fear the Water: An Underground Journey with Afghan Refugees, *he follows his friend, Omar, on his journey through Asia and Europe to find refuge in another country. Aikins goes undercover and disguises himself as a migrant named Habib in order to accurately report on the refugee journey and challenges at the border. Recently, Aikins and his team won two Emmy Awards for their groundbreaking reporting on a drone strike in Afghanistan that the U.S. government claimed was targeting an ISIS affiliate. Aikins' investigating revealed that the drone strike had destroyed the home of a family and killed ten people, including seven children. In 2022, this reporting helped make Aikins part of the team at the* Times *that won the Pulitzer Prize in International Reporting.*

Reporting from Afghanistan

An Interview with Pulitzer Prize Winner Matthieu Aikins

WHAT WAS IT LIKE TO GO UNDERCOVER AND LEAVE BEHIND YOUR PASSPORT AND THE PROTECTIONS IT GAVE YOU IN ORDER TO TAKE ON THE IDENTITY OF HABIB? WHY DID YOU WANT TO DO IT?

The journey that I made for my book as Habib was to witness firsthand what was happening on the border with smugglers, in detention centers, or refugees being kidnapped or arrested. The only way I could do that was to go undercover as a refugee myself. To choose to go undercover is a big decision. It's ethically fraught because it involves an act of deception and even breaking the law. Of course, there is a tradition of undercover journalism in the United States, and it's justified when it's the only way to get a story. The violence that was happening at the borders during the migration crisis was vitally important to shed light on.

SO MUCH OF YOUR JOURNALISM INVOLVES GROUNDBREAKING INVESTIGATORY WORK. WE ARE CURIOUS ABOUT YOUR PROCESS IN MAKING THESE REVELATIONS — HOW DO YOU UNCOVER STORIES?

It's obviously very difficult to figure out what the unknown revelation is in advance by its very nature. For the most part, it's been surprising to me as well. For me, it's always been important to go there and observe firsthand, and when you notice a discrepancy between the official narrative or what's publicly understood and what people are telling you on the ground, then that's usually a good indication that something's up and there could be a story there. That was certainly the case with the drone strike. Last summer, the morning after the explosion, my roommate and photographer Jim Huylebroek and I rode there on our motorcycles, and it was immediately apparent because it was a house with a family in it. People were crying and showing us pictures of little children who were killed in the explosion.

"I am trying to approach the country and situation with the most humility, which means learning, listening, and going there — even under difficult conditions."

HOW DO YOU AUTHENTICATE SOME OF THOSE EXPERIENCES OR STORIES? YOU ARE SPEAKING TO PEOPLE ABOUT DEEPLY PERSONAL AND TRAUMATIC EVENTS, BUT IT'S ALSO YOUR RESPONSIBILITY TO ENSURE THAT YOU ARE REPORTING THE TRUTH. HOW DOES THAT PROCESS OF VERIFICATION COME ABOUT?

As a journalist, it is our duty to provide a verifiable account of events. We have to fact check people even if they are talking about really terrible things. We want to do that sensitively. But if we can't do it that way, or if we can't do it at all, then I don't think that those are necessarily appropriate materials for journalism. Our job is to find accounts and experiences that we can verify. It's important to be sensitive while doing that, but that's not really an excuse, I think, to let our standards fall when it comes to writing the truth.

SINCE YOU TRAVELED WITH A FLEEING AFGHAN FAMILY, YOU WERE INVOLVED IN THEIR PERSONAL LIVES FOR AN EXTENDED PERIOD OF TIME. HOW DID YOU SEPARATE YOUR PERSONAL EMOTIONS FROM THE WORK THAT YOU WERE PRODUCING?

Well, I don't think you can. That was something I struggled with a lot during this book because I entered this project with the idea that I was doing this because I was a journalist. Yes, I was going undercover, but my illegal act of deception was justified by my professional status. Therefore, I would really just be an observer on this trip that involved traveling smugglers and other things that were quite shady. Yet, I was traveling with my friend and his family, and as a human being, I was responsible for my safety and his safety just as he was responsible for mine. So, I was pushed into a role that was much more of a participant. It was difficult and led to some crises, which I talked about in the book.

HOW HAS YOUR JOURNALISM CHANGED AFTER THE TALIBAN TOOK OVER IN AFGHANISTAN? HAS IT BEEN MORE DIFFICULT TO REPORT IN AFGHANISTAN SINCE?

I think in some ways it's surprising that we are still able to access Afghanistan at all, and that they are still allowing Western journalists to enter. I think the reason they are is because the country is dependent on Western humanitarian aid and NGOs, and they also want official recognition as the government — they want embassies to come back. I think they understand that allowing Western correspondents in is part of the package. So for now, we are able to go there.

It has been getting more difficult, and there have been more restrictions on reporters. I think it doesn't help that a lot of reporters are not really interested in understanding the current situation with the Taliban and how they're evolving. They just want to write about the bogeyman that's been the enemy for the United States for the last 20 years. Of course, there's lots of terrible stuff that's happening that they can write about, like the closure of girls' high schools, which I've written about as well. But I think it's very important to approach the situation with a bit of humility. Honestly, we

"For me, it's always been important to go there and observe firsthand, and when you notice a discrepancy between the official narrative or what's publicly understood and what people are telling you on the ground, then that's usually a good indication that something's up and there could be a story there."

were so deeply wrapped up in a web of illusions that no one saw the way that it would evaporate almost overnight with catastrophic consequences for the people of Afghanistan. Even as someone who has been a critic of the wars for the last 20 years, I feel like there was a lot that I missed that we didn't understand. I am trying to approach the country and situation with the most humility, which means learning, listening, and going there — even under difficult conditions.

SIMILARLY, HOW DO YOU THINK THE COVERAGE OF THE REFUGEE CRISIS OF 2015-2016 (WHERE AFGHANS WERE THE SECOND-LARGEST ETHNIC GROUP FLEEING, AFTER SYRIANS) CONTRASTS WITH THE COVERAGE OF UKRAINIAN REFUGEES SEEKING SUPPORT AND STABILITY?

A lot of people on the right in Europe have pointed out, as a way of justifying [less restrictions on immigration from Ukraine], that Ukrainians are white, Christian, and European and therefore deserve to be given refuge. Whereas brown, Muslim, refugees – like Afghans or Syrians – don't. So people are openly saying racist and xenophobic justifications for the obvious difference in treatment.

But I think it's more complicated than that. It also has to do with the way that the immigration systems are set up to filter people out from the developing world, from the Global South. The contrast in treatment between Afghan and Ukrainian refugees has shown us how much these great border crises are constructed by laws and not just the result of wars or other catastrophes. When Russia invaded Ukraine, Ukrainians were able to travel legally into the EU – they didn't need visas because they were granted visa-free entry. So they could get in the car and drive to Poland. They didn't have to pay smugglers to take them across deserts and forests or risk their lives on little boats. That, of course, is the situation for most refugees, for Afghan and Syrians. So the racialized differences are partly the result of a bigger economic picture that has to do with the disparities in global north and south.

I also think that it's easier to feel sympathy sometimes for people when you're not partially responsible for the catastrophe that they're fleeing. The irony here is that Europe and the United States have much less responsibility for making Ukrainians refugees than the disasters that Afghans or Syrians are facing.

DO YOU HAVE A STORY THAT FEELS UNFINISHED AND YOU WOULD LIKE TO CONTINUE WORKING ON?

In terms of unfinished work, there's a lot. For the first time in 20 years, in the rural parts of Afghanistan where the war was most violent, there's peace because the Taliban is in charge. You can work with them if you can get permission. Then you can travel to these areas and see places and people who were very, very difficult, if not impossible, to access. I feel like there's a whole new history of the war in Afghanistan that can be finally written for the first time since 2001. There's a tremendous opportunity and we don't know how long it's going to last. We don't know how much longer Western journalists will be able to work in Afghanistan. We don't know how much longer this window of peace is going to last either. There's a lot of unfinished work in terms of accounting for what went wrong over the last 20 years and the tremendous violence and corruption that our intervention inflicted on the country.

This interview has been condensed and edited for length and clarity.

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